
Beyond Repression: Network Analysis and Social Dynamics in Medieval Inquisition Records

Roberto Mussinatto^{*1,2,3}

¹Università degli Studi di Padova = University of Padua (Unipd) – Italy

²University of Venice Ca' Foscari = Université de Venise Ca' Foscari = Università Ca' Foscari di Venezia (Unive) – Italy

³Culture et Environnements, Préhistoire, Antiquité, Moyen-Age (CEPAM) – Université Nice Sophia Antipolis (1965 - 2019), Centre National de la Recherche Scientifique, Université Côte d'Azur – France

Abstract

A long-established approach to inquisitorial registers has conceived them primarily as texts whose multiple voices must be identified and disentangled (Ginzburg 1966, 1976; Arnold 2001; Bruschi 2003). More recent interpretive approaches have instead focused on both their materiality (Rehr 2023) and their relational dimension, given that the majority of the questions posed by inquisitors concerned deponents' relationships with other individuals and groups. In this context, historical network analysis tools appear particularly well suited to sampling inquisitorial trial records and thus to gaining a better understanding of how inquisitors worked (Nieto-Isabel and Lopez-Arenillas 2021).

Historical network analysis can be fruitfully employed as a source-critical instrument for the study of inquisitorial trial records. While unable to resolve all interpretive problems (Zbiral and Shaw 2022), it nonetheless shifts the way such sources are approached analytically and can shed some light on the social and political dynamics underlying the inquisitors' activities, which appear to extend far beyond the mere repression of heresy.

The argument is based on a network analysis of three datasets extracted from medieval inquisitorial trial records: Paris, Bibliothèque Nationale de France, fonds Doat 25–26; Bologna, Biblioteca dell'Archiginnasio, MS 1856; and Rome, Biblioteca Casanatense, MS 3217. The datasets were constructed by recording all the individuals mentioned in the depositions contained in these registers, including deponents, persons merely mentioned by them, and witnesses. Their place of origin, status, and role in the trial were also recorded, together with their kinship and acquaintance ties.

Accusation networks among deponents and networks formed through kinship and acquaintance ties were plotted as graphs using the digital humanities software Gephi. These two types of networks are compared in order to assess how the latter influenced the former, and to what extent inquisitorial investigative practices contributed to the formation of new networks based on deponents' testimonies and on the inquisitors' own aims and choices. The geographical visualisation of the data, produced using Nodegoat, further develops the analysis by highlighting whether inquisitors targeted individuals and groups located in specific places or regions whose local dynamics may have influenced their investigations.

^{*}Speaker

The results show that each inquiry followed markedly different trajectories, strongly shaped by the inquisitors' objectives and strategies, which were themselves closely connected to their embeddedness in the local contexts in which they operated. Inquisitorial investigations did not simply uncover pre-existing social relationships but actively reshaped them through the production of accusation networks reflecting both local dynamics and inquisitorial priorities. In this way, the usefulness of network analysis as a source-critical tool is demonstrated, together with the scope and limits of its applicability to inquisitorial trial records

References

Arnold, John H. 2001. *Inquisition and Power: Catharism and the Confessing Subject in Medieval Languedoc*. Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press.

Nieto-Isabel, Delfina I., and Carlos Lopez Arenillas. 2021. "From Inquisition to Inquiry: Inquisitorial Records as a Source for Social Network Analysis." In *Digital Humanities and Christianity: An Introduction*, edited by Tim Hutchings and Claire Clivaz, 195–212. Berlin: De Gruyter.

Rehr, Jean-Paul. 2023. *Heresy, Politics, and Inquisition in the County of Toulouse. Edition and Study of Bibliothèque municipale de Toulouse, ms. 609: The Register of the "Great Inquisition" at Toulouse, 1245-46*. PhD diss., Université Lumière – Lyon 2.

Zbiral, David and R. L. J. Shaw. 2022. Hearing Voices: Reapproaching Medieval Inquisition Records. *Religions* 13: 1175.

Keywords: Medieval Inquisition, trial records, heresy, social history

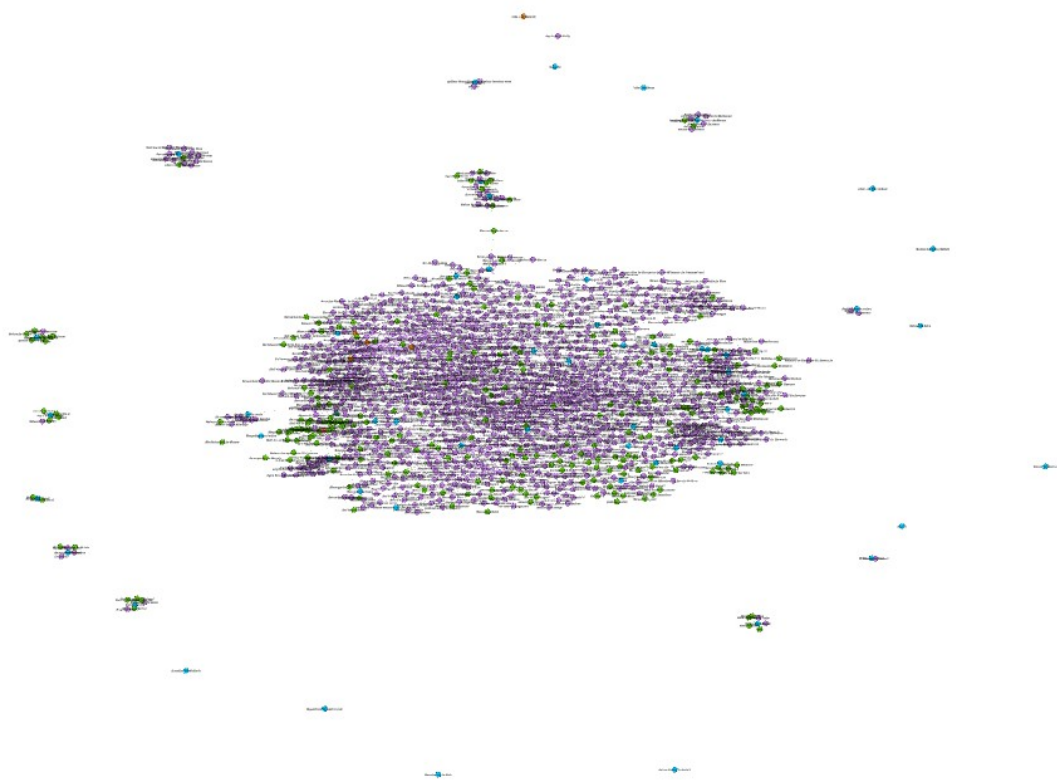


Figure 1. Incrimination network between people mentioned in the register Doat 25-26

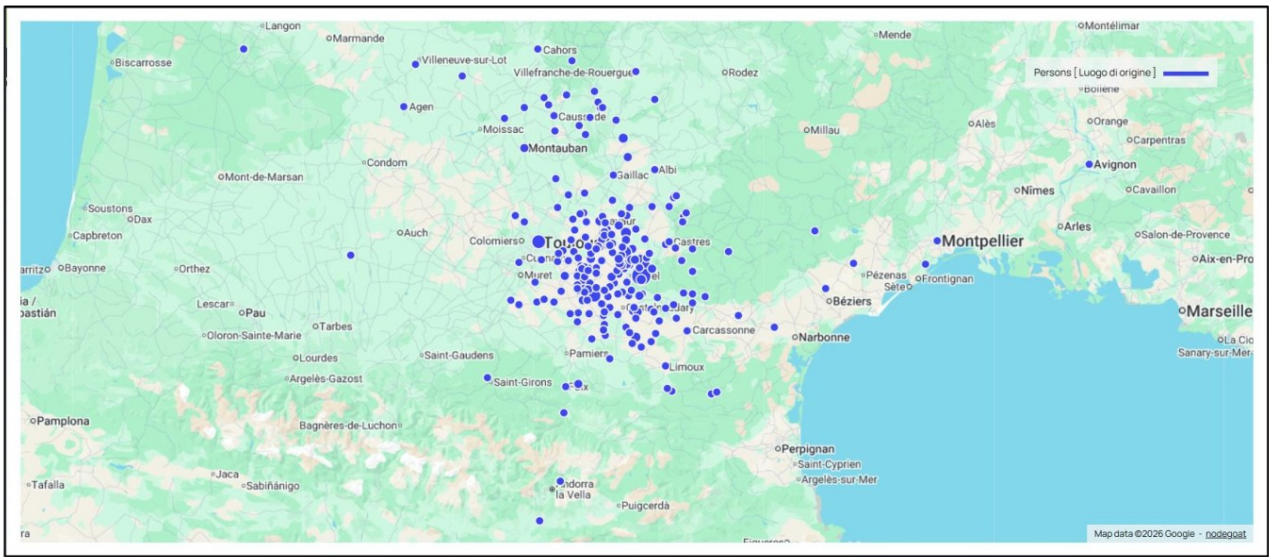


Figure 2. Map of the places of origin of the people mentioned in the register Doat 25-26.

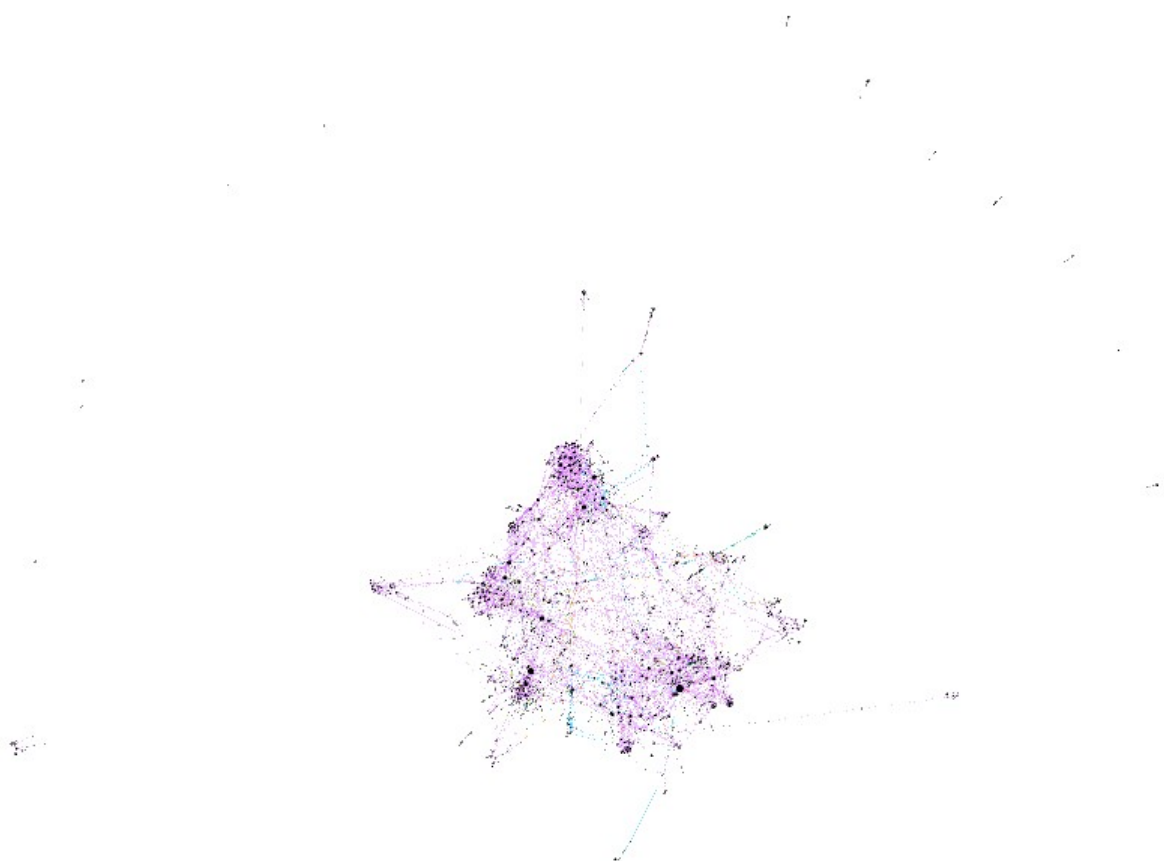


Figure 3. Kinship and acquaintance network between the people mentioned in the register Doat 25-26.